keySkillset

Salesforce Email Design Rulebook

Complete Guide — HTML Email Best Practices, Limits, Dark Mode, Accessibility & Deliverability

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1. Why This Rulebook Exists

This rulebook documents every HTML email lesson learned at keySkillset — from critical rendering failures during the March 2026 maintenance email project through to updated 2026 research on dark mode, accessibility, and deliverability. It is the single source of truth for anyone building or reviewing HTML emails that are sent via Salesforce.

Two Salesforce send methods are in scope for this document:

- List Email / Campaign Email — bulk sends from list views or campaign records
- Flow-triggered / Transactional Email — automated sends triggered by Salesforce Flow

> What went wrong in the March 2026 project: Original email used div/flexbox/animations — rejected by Salesforce. File size was 41,903 chars — exceeded the 32,000-char List Email limit. rgba() colours broke in Outlook, making text invisible. Logo pointed to a 404 URL. Inline SVGs used throughout — not supported in Outlook desktop. CSS animations stripped by every client. font-weight:800 silently ignored by Outlook.

2. Salesforce Character & Size Limits

Salesforce enforces HTML size limits depending on how the email is sent. Exceeding a limit throws a hard error that prevents sending. Salesforce also adds tracking wrapper markup on top of your template — this overhead must be accounted for in your target size.

Send Method	HTML Limit	Notes
List Email / Campaign Email	**32,000 chars**	Hard-coded in Lightning. Salesforce tracking overhead adds ~5–10K on top of your file size. This is what we hit in March 2026.
Flow-triggered / Transactional Email	**102,400 chars**	Higher limit for Flow/transactional sends. Standard template limit. Still subject to tracking overhead. Count characters before uploading.
Gmail Clipping Threshold	**102 KB file size**	Gmail clips email and shows "View entire message". Target under 80 KB file size to be safe. Affects all send methods.

Send Method	HTML Limit	Notes
Daily Mass Email Send Limit	**5,000/day (org)**	List Email sends count against the org-wide 5,000 daily mass email limit. Shared with all bulk/automated sends. Emails over limit are silently dropped.

> Rule of Thumb: Always target under 25,000 characters for List Email / Campaign sends. This gives Salesforce ~7,000 chars of tracking/wrapper headroom. Our final v4 maintenance email template was 14,576 chars — 54% under the limit. For Flow-triggered emails, target under 80,000 chars.

3. The Complete Rules — What To Do & What To Avoid

Every rule below is drawn from project failures, Salesforce documentation, and 2025–2026 email client research. Status indicators: REQUIRED = must follow; FORBIDDEN = never do; CAUTION = use carefully; NEW = added in v2.0.

Rule	Status	What breaks if you ignore it
LAYOUT & STRUCTURE		
Use table-based layout (table, tr, td)	REQUIRED	div/flexbox/grid breaks completely in Outlook (Word rendering engine). Layout collapses into a single column of unformatted text.
Max email width: 600–620px	REQUIRED	Wider emails cause horizontal scrolling on mobile. Content gets clipped or misaligned.
Single-column layout	REQUIRED	Multi-column layouts using CSS break in Outlook. Use nested tables for any column structure.
Use role="presentation" on layout tables	REQUIRED	Screen readers announce table structure to users. Accessibility standard for HTML email.
Use Flexbox or Grid	FORBIDDEN	Outlook ignores both entirely. Gmail mobile has partial support only. Layout breaks unpredictably.
Use position / float / clear	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by Outlook and Gmail. Elements overlap or disappear from view.
Use div, section, article, aside, nav for layout	FORBIDDEN	Outlook uses Word's engine which ignores these elements. Everything stacks or collapses.
Use HTML5 semantic elements	FORBIDDEN	Not supported in Outlook. Use table-based equivalents only.
CSS STYLING		
All critical CSS must be inline (style="...")	REQUIRED	Gmail strips <style> blocks entirely. Outlook ignores class-based styles. All layout, colour, and font styles must be on each element directly.
Add Outlook mso-table resets in <style> block	REQUIRED	Without mso-table-lspace/rspace:0pt, Outlook adds phantom gaps between table sections. Without #outlook a{padding:0}, Outlook pads all links.

Rule	Status	What breaks if you ignore it
Use rgba() or hsla() colours	FORBIDDEN	Outlook does not support rgba(). Text/backgrounds using rgba() become invisible or render as black. Always convert to solid hex.
Use CSS gradients (linear-gradient, radial-gradient)	FORBIDDEN	Outlook renders no gradient — falls back to solid colour or transparent. Use solid bgcolor on <td> instead.
Use CSS animations (@keyframes)	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by Outlook, Gmail, Yahoo. Animations don't play but add to file size and can trigger spam filters.
Use pseudo-elements (::before / ::after)	FORBIDDEN	Not supported in any major email client. Elements using them simply do not render.
Use CSS background-image property	FORBIDDEN	Outlook strips CSS background images completely. Use bgcolor attribute on <td> instead.
Use JavaScript of any kind	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by all email clients. Email is a static medium.
Use position, float, z-index, clear in CSS	FORBIDDEN	Stripped by Outlook and Gmail. Elements overlap or disappear.
Use font-weight above 700	FORBIDDEN	Outlook has no bold weight above 700. font-weight:800 or 900 is silently ignored — text appears as regular weight.
Use CSS shorthand properties (margin, padding, border)	CAUTION	Some clients only recognise individual properties. Write margin-top, margin-right etc. separately instead of margin: 0 0 8px 0.
Use box-shadow or text-shadow	CAUTION	Outlook ignores shadows completely. Safe to use, but don't rely on them for visual hierarchy.
Use border-radius	CAUTION	Outlook ignores border-radius — corners render as sharp squares. Visual only, layout is not broken.
FONTS & TYPOGRAPHY		
Use web-safe fonts only (Arial, Georgia, Verdana, Helvetica)	REQUIRED	Custom fonts are ignored by Outlook, Gmail, and Yahoo. Text falls back to Times New Roman, breaking the design.
Minimum font size: 14px body text	REQUIRED	Smaller text is unreadable on mobile. iOS auto-scales small text upward, potentially breaking layout.
Line height: 1.5–1.7 (use line-height attribute on <td>)	REQUIRED	Tighter line height makes text cramped and difficult to read on mobile screens.
Left-align body text	REQUIRED	Centre-aligned long text and justified text both reduce readability and fail WCAG 2.1 AA guidelines. Reserve centring for headlines and CTAs only.
Use Google Fonts or external @font-face	FORBIDDEN	Outlook ignores @font-face and Google Fonts imports entirely. Gmail also strips them. Only Apple Mail supports them.
IMAGES & MEDIA		
Use hosted images (Salesforce Content Library or CDN)	REQUIRED	Images not on a public URL won't load. Broken image icons appear instead.
Set file to "Externally Available" in Salesforce Content Library	REQUIRED	If not set externally available, the image returns a 401/403 error to external email clients. Logo won't load.
Always set width attribute on <img>	REQUIRED	Outlook uses the image's natural size if no width is set — can cause oversized images that break layout.

Rule	Status	What breaks if you ignore it
Always use height:auto in CSS, not hardcoded height	REQUIRED	Hardcoding both width and height squishes the image. Let height scale naturally.
Always include descriptive alt text on every <img>	REQUIRED	Many clients block images by default. Without alt text, recipients see a blank box. Fails WCAG 1.1.1.
Always add display:block to images	REQUIRED	Without display:block, images render inline and create phantom spacing below them in most clients.
For logo images: use PNG with transparent or white background	REQUIRED	Logos with dark text on a transparent background become invisible in dark mode. Use a solid or contrasted background.
Use base64-encoded images	FORBIDDEN	Dramatically increases file size. Many clients block base64 images as a security measure. Broken in Outlook.
Use inline SVG elements	FORBIDDEN	SVG is not supported in Outlook desktop at all. Renders as blank space. Replace with PNG or text symbols.
Use CSS background-image for visible images	FORBIDDEN	Outlook strips CSS background images. Use bgcolor on <td> for colour. For visible images, use <img> only.
DARK MODE (NEW IN V2.0)		
Add <meta name="color-scheme" content="light"> to <head>	REQUIRED	Without this, some clients apply full colour inversion by default, making your design unreadable.
Add <meta name="supported-color-schemes" content="light"> to <head>	REQUIRED	Required alongside color-scheme for Apple Mail to honour your light-mode intent.
Never use pure #000000 or #FFFFFF for critical text or backgrounds	CAUTION	Apple Mail fully inverts pure black and white regardless of contrast rules. Use near-equivalents such as #000001 or #FFFFFE instead.
Add Outlook dark mode conditional: mso gradient override in <style>	CAUTION	Outlook on Windows (2021+, 365) aggressively inverts colours. MSO conditional gradient hacks can preserve specific text/background colours. Test thoroughly.
Add [data-ogsc] selectors in <style> for Outlook.com dark mode	CAUTION	Outlook.com uses partial colour inversion. Duplicating @media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) rules with [data-ogsc] prefix gives more control over Outlook.com rendering.
Avoid transparent image backgrounds if image contains dark elements	REQUIRED	Dark text/icons on transparent background become invisible against dark mode backgrounds. Use opaque white or contrasted backgrounds on image assets.
Test in actual dark mode inboxes — not browser preview	REQUIRED	Dark mode behaviour differs radically between Gmail app, Apple Mail, Outlook 365, and Outlook.com. Browser preview does not show dark mode rendering.
ACCESSIBILITY (WCAG 2.1 AA) (NEW IN V2.0)		
Set lang attribute on <html> element (e.g. lang="en")	REQUIRED	Screen readers use the lang attribute to select the correct language/accent for voice output. WCAG 3.1.1 failure without it.
Minimum colour contrast ratio: 4.5:1 for body text	REQUIRED	Fails WCAG 1.4.3 (Contrast Minimum). Text becomes unreadable for users with low vision or colour blindness. Verify with WebAIM Contrast Checker.

Rule	Status	What breaks if you ignore it
Minimum colour contrast ratio: 3:1 for large text (18px+ or 14px+ bold)	REQUIRED	Lower threshold for large text under WCAG 1.4.3, but still must be verified. Do not rely on "looks fine" — measure it.
Never use colour as the sole method of conveying information	REQUIRED	Fails WCAG 1.4.1. Users with colour blindness cannot distinguish information presented only through colour. Always pair colour with text or an icon.
Use logical heading structure (h1, h2, h3) in email copy	REQUIRED	Screen readers navigate by heading structure. Skipping levels or using headings only for size creates confusing navigation for blind users.
Add aria-label to CTA links that lack descriptive visible text	REQUIRED	Screen readers read link text aloud. "Click here" or "Learn more" alone fails WCAG 2.4.6. Write aria-label="Set password and log in to keySkillset" instead.
Minimum tap target size: 44 x 44px for buttons and links	REQUIRED	Smaller targets are difficult to tap on mobile. Fails WCAG 2.5.5. Poor UX and accessibility for motor-impaired users.
Maintain 80:20 text-to-image ratio	REQUIRED	Screen readers cannot interpret image content. Emails that are mostly images exclude users relying on assistive technology. Also flagged by spam filters.
Do not use colour alone for link differentiation from body text	CAUTION	Fails WCAG 1.4.1 if contrast between link and surrounding text is below 3:1. Add underline or other visual distinction.
Add aria-hidden="true" to decorative emoji or icons	CAUTION	Screen readers will read out emoji names aloud (e.g. "party popper"). Decorative emoji should be hidden from assistive technology.
MERGE FIELDS & PERSONALISATION TOKENS (NEW IN V2.0)		
Count characters with merge fields at their maximum expected length	REQUIRED	Merge fields like {{org_name}} expand at send time. A 10-char token could become a 50-char value. Always estimate worst-case file size before uploading.
Use Salesforce standard merge field syntax: {{{field_name}}}	REQUIRED	Custom template syntax is ignored or rendered literally. Use Salesforce-standard fields from the template editor.
Test merge fields using Send Test with actual records	REQUIRED	Merge field errors only surface at render time. A null field can break layout or produce blank sections. Always test with real data.
Never put merge fields inside CSS property values	FORBIDDEN	Salesforce does not resolve merge fields inside <style> blocks. The CSS will be rendered literally and break styling.
Never use merge fields in image src="" URLs	CAUTION	Dynamic image URLs from merge fields are unreliable. Host images in Salesforce Content Library and use fixed URLs.
Add fallback text for every merge field	CAUTION	If a field is null for a recipient, nothing renders. Use Salesforce IF/ELSE merge syntax to provide fallback copy.
SALESFORCE-SPECIFIC RULES		
Keep List Email template under 25,000 characters	REQUIRED	Salesforce List Email limit is 32,000 chars. Tracking wrappers add ~5–10K. Exceeding limit throws "This email template is too big" error and blocks sending.
Keep Flow-triggered email template under 80,000 characters	REQUIRED	Applies to Stay within safe headroom below the 102,400-char standard template limit.

Rule	Status	What breaks if you ignore it
Host all images in Salesforce Content Library	REQUIRED	External URLs may be blocked by Salesforce's security policies. Salesforce-hosted images are served from trusted domains.
Always send a test email before scheduling	REQUIRED	Salesforce renders differently from browser preview. Tracking wrappers, link rewrites, and merge fields can change the final output.
Use custom HTML email template (not Letterhead)	REQUIRED	Classic Letterhead templates add extra markup and override your styling. Use Custom HTML template type for full control.
Avoid spam trigger words in subject line and body copy	CAUTION	Words like "Urgent", "Act Now", "Free", excessive ALL CAPS, and multiple !!! increase spam score. See Section 7 for the full list.
MOBILE COMPATIBILITY		
Add viewport meta tag to <head>	REQUIRED	Without viewport meta, mobile clients render the email at desktop width and scale it down — text becomes unreadably small.
Add -webkit-text-size-adjust:100% to body CSS	REQUIRED	iOS automatically enlarges small text. This resets it and preserves the intended layout.
Add x-apple-disable-message-reformatting meta to <head>	REQUIRED	Without this, Apple Mail on iOS reformats the email — scaling and reflowing content unexpectedly.
Use @media query block for mobile overrides	REQUIRED	Without responsive overrides, desktop font sizes and padding are too large/small on mobile. Note: Gmail app strips media queries — ensure desktop styles are readable on mobile too.

4. Dark Mode — How Each Client Behaves

Dark mode is now mainstream across all major email clients. Each client handles dark mode differently, and the differences are significant enough that you must understand them before designing any keySkillset email. There are three behaviours in the wild:

Client	Dark Mode Type	What It Does To Your Email
Outlook 2021 / 365 (Windows)	Full colour inversion	Aggressively inverts all colours. Light backgrounds become dark. Dark text becomes light. Even explicitly set colours with !important are overridden via data-ogsb / data-ogsc attributes. Use MSO conditional gradients to work around.
Outlook.com (web)	Partial colour inversion	Inverts light backgrounds and dark text. Leaves dark sections largely alone. Targetable via [data-ogsc] CSS selectors.
Apple Mail (macOS / iOS)	Partial inversion + meta tag support	Respects <meta name="color-scheme" content="light">. Fully inverts pure #000000 and #FFFFFF — use near-equivalents like #000001 or #FFFFFE to avoid this.
Gmail app (iOS)	Full colour inversion	Forces dark mode on light emails. Can be partially controlled via mix-blend-mode hack. No @media support.

Client	Dark Mode Type	What It Does To Your Email
Gmail (web)	No change / partial	Gmail web does not aggressively force dark mode. Generally leaves your email as-is. @media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) is partially supported.
Yahoo Mail	No change	Yahoo Mail does not apply dark mode to email content. Your light theme renders as-is.

Minimum Dark Mode Code Requirements

Every keySkillset email sent through Salesforce must include the following in the <head>:

```
<meta name="color-scheme" content="light">
<meta name="supported-color-schemes" content="light">
```

5. What Breaks, Where & Why — Quick Reference

Symptom	Likely Cause	Client(s)	Fix
Layout collapses to single column	Using div/flexbox for layout	Outlook	Rebuild using nested tables only
Text is invisible on coloured background	rgba() colours used	Outlook	Replace all rgba() with solid hex equivalents
Background is flat or missing	CSS gradient used	Outlook	Use solid bgcolor on <td> instead
Logo shows broken image icon	URL wrong / not public / not Externally Available	All clients	Host in Salesforce Content Library, set Externally Available
Logo is squished or stretched	Both width & height hardcoded on <img>	All clients	Set width attribute only; use height:auto in CSS
"Email is too big" error	File over 32,000 chars (List Email)	Salesforce	Minify HTML, remove sections. Target under 25,000 chars.
Fonts look different than expected	Custom or Google Font used	Outlook, Gmail	Use Arial, Georgia, Verdana only
Text appears in regular weight	font-weight:800 or 900 used	Outlook	Cap font-weight to 700
Gaps between table sections	mso-table resets missing	Outlook	Add mso-table-lspace:0pt; mso-table-rspace:0pt in <style>
Images too large or break layout	No width attribute on <img>	Outlook	Always set width attribute and max-width in style
Phantom space below images	No display:block on images	All clients	Always add display:block to all <img> tags
Email clipped with "View entire message"	File over 102 KB	Gmail	Minify and remove unused sections. Target under 80 KB.
Animations not playing	@keyframes used	All clients	Remove animations — use static design only
SVG not visible	Inline SVG used	Outlook	Replace SVG with text symbols, Unicode, or hosted PNG

Symptom	Likely Cause	Client(s)	Fix
Logo invisible in dark mode	Dark logo on transparent PNG background	Apple Mail, Gmail iOS, Outlook 365	Export logo with opaque white or contrasted background
Text becomes white-on-white in dark mode	Pure #FFFFFF text with light background — inverted by client	Apple Mail	Use #FFFFFE instead of #FFFFFF; add color-scheme meta tags
Merge field renders as literal text	Wrong syntax or field not available on record	Salesforce	Use Salesforce standard merge syntax; test with Send Test
Screen reader reads emoji names aloud	Decorative emoji not hidden	Screen readers (all clients)	Add aria-hidden="true" to decorative emoji spans
Low-contrast text fails accessibility audit	Colour contrast ratio below 4.5:1	All clients	Check all text/background combinations with WebAIM Contrast Checker

6. Deliverability & Spam Avoidance

Spam filters in 2026 use machine learning and evaluate dozens of signals simultaneously — not just keywords. The following rules apply to all Salesforce sends from keySkillset.

6.1 — Technical Authentication (Non-Negotiable)

These must be configured at the domain level before any email is sent. If you are unsure whether these are set up, ask the Salesforce administrator.

Authentication Protocol	What It Does
SPF (Sender Policy Framework)	A DNS record listing IP addresses authorised to send email from your domain. Prevents spoofing.
DKIM (DomainKeys Identified Mail)	Adds a cryptographic signature to every email proving it came from your domain and was not tampered with in transit.
DMARC (Domain-based Message Authentication)	Ties SPF and DKIM together. Tells receiving servers what to do with emails that fail authentication. Required by Gmail and Yahoo for bulk senders in 2024 onwards.

6.2 — Content Rules

- Maintain a minimum 60:40 text-to-image ratio. Image-only emails are flagged by spam filters because they cannot read the text inside images.
- Avoid link shorteners (e.g. bit.ly). These are heavily used by spammers to hide malicious URLs. Use full URLs or hyperlinked anchor text.
- Limit links to 2–3 per email where possible. Excessive links are a spam signal.
- Never use ALL CAPS in the subject line or body. A consistent spam signal across all major filters.
- Avoid excessive punctuation (!!!, ???, $$$). Flagged by all major content filters.
- Keep HTML clean and well-formed. Broken tags, messy nesting, and malformed markup suggest spam or phishing toolkits. Validate before sending.

- Never reuse the same template verbatim indefinitely. Spam filters detect high-volume identical emails. Rotate copy and structure periodically.

6.3 — Subject Line Spam Trigger Words to Avoid

The following categories of words are flagged by spam filters in 2026. Use natural, specific language instead:

Category	Examples to Avoid	Safe Alternatives
Urgency	Urgent, Act Now, Final Notice, Last Chance, Hurry	Use specific deadlines: "Respond by Friday 25 April"
Financial promise	Free, Earn money, Cash, Save big, Lowest price, 100% guarantee	Describe actual value without promotional framing
Aggressive CTA	Click here, Buy now, Order now, Subscribe now	Use descriptive anchor text: "Set your password", "View your dashboard"
Deceptive framing	You've been selected, Congratulations, Winner, Exclusive offer	Be direct and specific about what the email is
Excessive formatting	ALL CAPS, multiple !!!, $$$, excessive emoji	Use sentence case, standard punctuation, one emoji maximum in subject

6.4 — Physical Address & Legal Requirements

CAN-SPAM (US) and GDPR (EU) both require a physical mailing address in every commercial email footer. keySkillset emails must include the company address and a functional unsubscribe link in every send. Never remove the legal footer copy — it is compliance-required.

7. Testing Workflow — Required Before Every Send

No email should be scheduled for live send before completing the following checklist. Browser preview in Salesforce is insufficient — you must test in actual email clients.

7.1 — Pre-Upload Checks

☐	Count characters — confirm under 25,000 for List Email sends, or under 80,000 for Flow-triggered sends
☐	Validate HTML — no unclosed tags, no broken nesting. Run through an HTML validator.
☐	Check file size (not character count) — confirm email is under 80 KB to avoid Gmail clipping
☐	Verify all image URLs are live, publicly accessible, and hosted in Salesforce Content Library
☐	Confirm all images have width attribute set and display:block applied
☐	Replace all rgba() colours with solid hex equivalents
☐	Replace all Google Fonts imports with web-safe font stack

☐	Cap all font-weight values at 700
☐	Confirm no inline SVG elements remain — replace with PNG or Unicode symbols
☐	Confirm no CSS animations or @keyframes remain
☐	Add color-scheme and supported-color-schemes meta tags for dark mode
☐	Verify merge fields use correct Salesforce syntax and have fallback values
☐	Check all text/background contrast ratios using WebAIM Contrast Checker (minimum 4.5:1)
☐	Confirm alt text is present and descriptive on every <img> element
☐	Verify lang attribute is set on <html> element
☐	Confirm CTA links have descriptive aria-label attributes
☐	Check subject line and body copy for spam trigger words (Section 6.3)

7.2 — Salesforce Send Test

☐	Upload template to Salesforce and use "Send Test" to send a preview to your own inbox
☐	Send test to at least: Gmail (web), Outlook desktop (2019 or 365), iPhone Mail
☐	Enable dark mode on each test device and re-check every client
☐	Verify logo loads correctly in all three clients
☐	Verify all colours are correct (no invisible text, no inverted sections)
☐	Verify layout holds — no collapsed columns, no phantom gaps, no oversized images
☐	Verify CTA link is functional and points to the correct URL
☐	Verify merge fields resolve correctly (or test with actual record data)
☐	Verify email is readable at mobile width without horizontal scrolling
☐	Use a spam testing tool (Mail-Tester.com or Litmus Spam Filter Testing) before the live send

7.3 — Recommended Testing Tools

Tool	What It Tests
Salesforce Send Test (built-in)	Tests merge field resolution, tracking wrappers, Salesforce link rewrites
Litmus (paid)	Preview in 90+ email clients including Outlook 2013/2016/2019/365, Gmail app, Apple Mail dark mode
Email on Acid (paid)	Cross-client rendering, spam filter testing, accessibility checker, dark mode preview
Mail-Tester.com (free)	Full spam score including SPF/DKIM/DMARC check, content analysis, HTML quality score

WebAIM Contrast Checker (free)	Checks text/background colour contrast against WCAG 2.1 AA (4.5:1 ratio)
Parcel.io email code editor (free tier)	Real-time rendering with dark mode preview — faster than Litmus for quick iteration

8. Recommended Email Build Workflow

Step 1 — Design with Constraints in Mind

- Use solid colours only — no gradients, no rgba()
- Plan for single-column layout using tables from the start
- Only use Arial, Helvetica, Georgia, or Verdana
- Avoid pure #000000 or #FFFFFF — use near-equivalents for dark mode safety
- Export logo as PNG with opaque background (not transparent) for dark mode safety
- Keep copy short — fewer sections equals smaller file size

Step 2 — Build the HTML

- Table-based structure — every layout element must use <table> + <tr> + <td>
- All CSS inline on every element — no external stylesheets, no class-based styles
- Replace all rgba() with solid hex before finishing
- Cap font-weight at 700 throughout
- Add role="presentation" on all layout tables
- Set width + valign attributes directly on <td>, not only in CSS
- Add Outlook mso-table resets in <style> block in <head>
- Add mobile @media query block for responsive overrides
- Add color-scheme and supported-color-schemes meta tags in <head>
- Use bgcolor attribute on <td> as well as background-color in CSS
- Add lang="en" (or appropriate language) on <html> element
- Add aria-label on all CTA links

Step 3 — Images

- Upload all images to Salesforce Content Library
- Set each file to "Externally Available"
- Get the public URL from the developer and use it in src=""
- Set width attribute on every <img> — never hardcode height
- Set height:auto in CSS, display:block always
- Write descriptive alt text for every image
- Ensure logo PNG has an opaque (non-transparent) background

Step 4 — Check File Size Before Uploading

- Count characters — target under 25,000 for List Email / Campaign sends
- Target under 80,000 characters for Flow-triggered sends
- If over: minify first (remove whitespace, comments), then remove sections
- Never remove footer legal copy — required for CAN-SPAM and GDPR compliance
- Check file size is under 80 KB to avoid Gmail clipping

Step 5 — Test Before Sending

- Complete the full pre-upload checklist in Section 7.1
- Upload to Salesforce and run Send Test — check in Gmail, Outlook desktop, and iPhone Mail
- Enable dark mode on each test device and recheck
- Run through Mail-Tester.com for spam score
- Only schedule the live send after a fully clean test pass

9. Quick Reference Cheatsheet

Always USE

- table, tr, td for all layout
- Inline CSS on every element: style="..."
- bgcolor attribute on td in addition to background-color in CSS
- width attribute on td and img
- valign attribute on td
- role="presentation" on layout tables
- display:block on all images
- height:auto in CSS for images
- Descriptive alt text on all images
- Web-safe fonts only: Arial, Helvetica, Georgia, Verdana
- Solid hex colours only — e.g. #0D2D6B not rgba()
- font-weight: 700 maximum
- Salesforce Content Library for all image hosting
- mso-table-lspace:0pt and mso-table-rspace:0pt in <style>
- Mobile @media query overrides
- color-scheme and supported-color-schemes meta tags
- lang attribute on <html>
- aria-label on CTA links
- 4.5:1 minimum contrast ratio on all text
- Merge field fallback values for null records

Never USE

- div, section, article for layout
- display:flex, display:grid
- rgba() or hsla() for any colour
- CSS gradients (linear-gradient, radial-gradient)
- @keyframes or any CSS animations
- ::before or ::after pseudo-elements
- Inline SVG elements
- base64-encoded images
- Google Fonts or any external @font-face
- font-weight: 800 or 900
- CSS background-image (use bgcolor on td instead)
- JavaScript of any kind
- position, float, z-index, or clear in CSS
- HTML5 semantic elements (section, article, aside, nav)
- Pure #000000 or #FFFFFF for critical text or backgrounds
- Transparent PNG backgrounds on logos or icons with dark elements
- Merge fields inside CSS property values

10. What We Fixed — Project Change Log

This is a record of every change made to the keySkillset maintenance email (March 2026) and why it was necessary. It also documents the violations identified in shine-welcome-v3.html that must be resolved before that template is sent via Salesforce.

10.1 — Maintenance Email Fixes (March 2026)

#	Change	Reason
1	**Fixed broken closing HTML tags**	File was truncated — tags missing at end of file, causing rendering failure
2	**Updated Started time to 11:00 AM IST**	Incorrect time in original file
3	**Removed Maintenance In Progress pill & clock SVG icon**	Visual cleanup — SVG not supported in Outlook
4	**Removed Wave divider, Pre-header, Motivation quote**	File size reduction for Salesforce 32K character limit
5	**Fixed Back Online cell — date/time were swapped**	Date was in time position, time was in date position
6	**Reduced time grid from 3 cells to 2 (Started + Back Online)**	Simplified and reduced file size
7	**Swapped hero subtext sentence order**	Copy flow improvement
8	**Widened hero-sub max-width from 410px to 460px**	Prevented awkward mid-phrase line breaks

#	Change	Reason
9	**Full rebuild — div/flex to table-based inline CSS**	Original file incompatible with Salesforce and Outlook
10	**Removed all rgba() — converted to solid hex**	rgba() not supported in Outlook — invisible text/backgrounds
11	**Removed all inline SVGs — replaced with text symbols**	SVG not supported in Outlook desktop
12	**Removed CSS animations and @keyframes**	Stripped by all email clients, adds to file size
13	**Removed Google Fonts import**	Not supported by Outlook or Gmail
14	**Capped font-weight to 700**	Outlook ignores 800/900 — falls back to regular weight
15	**Added Outlook mso-table resets**	Prevents phantom gaps between table sections in Outlook
16	**Added mobile @media query block**	Responsive scaling for mobile email clients
17	**Replaced logo URL with Salesforce Content Library URL**	Original URL returned 404 — image not loading
18	**Removed hardcoded height from logo img**	Logo was squished — natural aspect ratio now preserved
19	**Updated times to 12:00 PM / 12:00 AM on 18–19 March**	Final confirmed maintenance window

10.2 — shine-welcome-v3.html: Violations Requiring Fix Before Salesforce Send

The welcome email HTML file (shine-welcome-v3.html) was designed as a browser preview and is not Salesforce/Outlook-safe in its current form. The following violations were identified and must be resolved before this template is sent via Salesforce:

#	Change	Reason
V1	**Google Fonts @import — remove**	@import url(Google Fonts) in <style> — stripped by Outlook and Gmail. Replace with Arial/Helvetica stack.
V2	**rgba() colours throughout — replace all**	box-shadow, border, and overlay colours use rgba(). Invisible in Outlook. Convert every instance to solid hex.
V3	**CSS gradients on hero, card, CTA button — remove**	linear-gradient used on .hero, .onboarding-card, .cta-btn. Falls back to transparent in Outlook. Replace with solid bgcolor on <td>.
V4	**display:flex throughout — rebuild with tables**	Used on .cobrand-strip, .features-row, .card-step, .cert-teaser, .pm-note, .card-tour-row. Outlook ignores flex entirely. Full table-based rebuild required.
V5	**.hero::before pseudo-element — remove**	::before used for radial gradient overlay on hero. Not supported in any email client. Remove entirely.
V6	**font-weight:800 throughout — cap at 700**	Used on .hero h1, multiple headings, and bold labels. Silently ignored by Outlook — renders as regular weight.
V7	**position:relative / position:absolute — remove**	Used on .hero and .hero::before. Stripped by Outlook and Gmail. Remove or rebuild without positioning.
V8	**div-based layout — full table rebuild required**	Entire document uses div-based layout (.email-wrapper, .hero, .body-section etc.). Incompatible with Outlook. Full rebuild to table/tr/td required.
V9	**-webkit-background-clip: text (gradient text effect) — remove**	Used on .gradient-text class for the hero headline. Not supported in Outlook. Replace with solid colour text.

#	Change	Reason
V10	**No color-scheme meta tags — add**	Missing <meta name="color-scheme"> and <meta name="supported-color-schemes">. Required for dark mode safety. Add to <head>.
V11	**No lang attribute on <html> — add**	Missing lang="en" on the root <html> element. Required for screen reader language detection. WCAG 3.1.1 failure.
V12	**No aria-label on CTA links — add**	cta-btn and tour-btn links lack aria-label attributes. Screen readers only read visible text. Add descriptive aria-labels.

11. The Golden Rules

Rule 1: If you cannot explain how Gmail AND Outlook will render it — do not ship it.

Rule 2: Email clients are not browsers. Treat every email like it will be opened in Outlook 2013 on Windows.

Rule 3: Simple, table-based, inline-CSS emails always win over complex, modern CSS emails.

Rule 4: Test in actual inboxes — not browser preview. Browser preview lies.

When in doubt: flat colour, web-safe font, hosted image, table layout.

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